



CASE STUDY | VENTURA COLLEGE

Re-envisioning ESL Programming from the Outside Looking In

Using qualitative research insights from Hanover, Ventura College rebuilt its English as a Second Language (ESL) program to drive enrollment through culturally relevant and community-focused learning.



THE CLIENT

Ventura College, the flagship of the Ventura County Community College District in California, serves up to 14,000 students annually.

INSTITUTION TYPE

Community College

LOCATION

Ventura, CA

THE CHALLENGE

Capture insights from students, staff, and community members to understand why the ESL program was failing and how the College could reimagine it to meet local needs.

HANOVER SOLUTION

In-depth interviews, focus groups

Sixty miles north of Los Angeles, amid sea breezes and strawberry fields, Ventura College has served its community for nearly a century. As a Hispanic-Serving Institution (HSI) in a diverse county, the college used to serve around 2,000 English as a Second Language (ESL) students a year. Yet by 2020, that number dwindled to 300, despite the county being home to more than 300,000 limited-English language speakers.

Recognizing a missed opportunity, college administrators set out to identify any institutional barriers preventing the program from meeting local needs. Knowing an outside party would bring a fresh lens, Ventura partnered with Hanover Research to investigate how to turn the program around.

THE CHALLENGE

In Ventura County, over half of working-age adults speak a language other than English at home, providing the College with a significant opportunity to serve English language learner needs. Yet the college's ESL class fill rates were regularly falling below 50%, resulting in frequent cancellations and students who were uncertain if they could count on the college. From a revenue standpoint, it became harder to justify the costs of running the program, despite Ventura's best efforts to promote it.

"We knew we needed a qualitative research approach to understand why our ESL class fill rates were so low, and we knew we needed to conduct that field research in Spanish, with native Spanish speakers. Much to our delight, Hanover accepted the challenge."

Jennifer Kalfsbeek-Goetz

Vice President for Academic Affairs and Student Learning

The college hired Hanover to conduct focus groups and in-depth interviews with internal and external stakeholders to uncover the program's weaknesses. The college stressed that these conversations must take place in Spanish in familiar community locations. Despite the complexities of doing this work during the pandemic, Hanover Research accepted the challenge.

Find out how partnering with Hanover can help you uncover the root causes of your enrollment challenges. [Learn more.](#)



>300,000

The number of Ventura County residents who have at least some difficulties speaking English

THE SOLUTION: GATHER INSIGHTS FROM THE COMMUNITY

Together, Hanover and Ventura College developed a plan to explore their target audience's perceptions about the college and learn from community members what programs and services could help meet their learning needs. Hanover proposed three qualitative research projects to assess the current program's strengths and weaknesses and identify the factors affecting student enrollment.

“Through partnering with Hanover, it has been invaluable for us to have that additional set of eyes, that outsider’s perspective helping us see what we are doing and what we can do differently.”

Jennifer Kalfsbeek-Goetz
Vice President for Academic Affairs and Student Learning

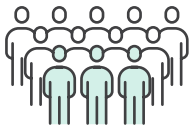
THE OUTCOME: BETTER VISIBILITY, ACCESS, AND STUDENT RECOGNITION

The research generated new insights about Ventura's challenges: a misunderstanding of student needs, a difficult application process, a lack of support staff, and limited visibility in the community. Analyzing these findings, Hanover provided a set of actionable recommendations.



300

The approximate number of ESL students Ventura College served in 2021



2,000

The number of ESL students Ventura College aims to serve annually by 2025

In 2022, Ventura College was named a national Bellwether Award finalist for its ESL best practices. The college has taken many lessons to heart and continues to bring a community engagement approach and a student-first lens to its institutional systems. By boldly re-envisioning the ESL program, the college is on track to reach its goal of enrolling 2,000 ESL students annually by 2025, the institution's centennial anniversary.

Hear how other community colleges are responding to the needs of their diverse students. Watch the webinar **Meeting the Needs of an Increasingly Diverse Student Population**.



TO DO THIS, HANOVER CONDUCTED THE FOLLOWING:



INTERNAL STAKEHOLDER INTERVIEWS

Hanover conducted in-depth interviews with current and former ESL students and faculty. These conversations uncovered a mismatch between the ESL for-credit course structure and students' non-credit learning goals.



EXTERNAL STAKEHOLDER INTERVIEWS

Next, Hanover conducted in-depth interviews with community members and educational representatives. They articulated their unmet needs and offered ideas to engage the community and identify local "champions" to access more Spanish-speaking groups and organizations.



COMMUNITY FOCUS GROUPS

Finally, Hanover conducted three focus group sessions with community members, hosted by two well-known organizations. These conversations revealed what the community wanted in an ESL program and provided insights on improving the college's community connections.

HANOVER'S RECOMMENDATIONS RESULTED IN:

PERSONNEL ACTIONS

- Solidified a bilingual, culturally competent ESL team at the East campus in Santa Paula
- Hired a dedicated employee to coordinate ESL outreach and recruitment

COMMUNITY ENGAGEMENT CHANGES

- Built strategic partnerships with local organizations and school districts
- Began offering ESL classes at a community center
- Launched targeted marketing and social media outreach

ONBOARDING IMPROVEMENTS

- Moved outreach events into the community to facilitate greater attendance
- Transitioned lengthy online application to a bilingual one-page paper application
- Made support available to students by phone, video calls, and walk-in service

ACHIEVEMENT OPPORTUNITIES

- Started issuing ESL certificates of achievement to formally recognize student accomplishments
- Began pairing some courses with bookkeeping and agricultural vocational training